

COCKATIEL · *NYMPHICUS HOLLANDICUS*

The first parrot, done properly.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: cage setup, a pellet-forward diet and how to actually get there, night frights, household hazards, hormones and eggs, and the health pages that decide whether you get a five-year cockatiel or a twenty-five-year one.

INSIDE

- ✓ Cage sizing, bar spacing, and the night-light that prevents a real injury
- ✓ Five pellet conversion methods, three food charts, and the never-feed list
- ✓ Sexing after the first molt, a gram scale routine, and reading the crest
- ✓ Nine health pages, a symptom table, and fillable owner, vet and sitter sheets

40 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

Version 1.2 · Oct 2026



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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't bought a bird yet

Read pages 4 through 12 in order before buying anything. Two decisions cost the most to undo: the cage on page 5, which people buy small and replace inside a year, and whether you bring home one cockatiel or two on page 9, which decides how tame the bird becomes and how much of your evening it needs. Settle both, then use the Budget and Shopping List on page 30 to buy once instead of twice.

If your cockatiel is already home

Start with the Setup Checklist on page 28 to audit what you have, then page 10 if the bird is on a seed mix. Diet is the single biggest lever on how long a cockatiel lives, and the conversion takes weeks or months, so starting it today matters more than finishing this book first. Then page 7, because a night light costs almost nothing and prevents the one injury this species is famous for. If anything looks wrong, go straight to Health Red Flags on page 19.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 28: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 35: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 29: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 36: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 32: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 37: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 33: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 26: Reading Droppings & Hydration |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

The cockatiel is sold as the easy, gentle, cheap first parrot, and most of that is true. What follows from it is not: a lot of the care advice still in circulation was written for a bird nobody expected to keep for twenty years. A seed bowl, a tall narrow cage bought for its looks, and a bedroom that stays dark and silent all night are all still normal advice somewhere, and all three shorten the bird's life or injure it. Every figure here is cross-checked against veterinary sources, listed on page 39, and every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is a professional call, not a page in this book. Cockatiels hide illness until they are genuinely sick, and at 90 g the margin afterwards is hours, not days. Find a vet before you need one and write the number on page 29.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Nymphicus hollandicus</i> . The smallest member of the cockatoo family, and the only species in its genus
Adult size	About 12.5 in (32 cm) head to tail tip. Roughly half of that is tail
Adult weight	80 to 125 g, average about 90 g. Your bird's own stable baseline matters more than the range. Page 16
Captive lifespan	12 to 15 years typically, with up to 25 reported. The gap is almost entirely diet and veterinary care: page 10 and page 20
Native range	Inland Australia. Nomadic flocks that follow water and seeding grasses
Diet type	Grass-seed eater in the wild, kept on a pellet-forward diet in captivity. Page 10
Cage floor, one bird	20×20 in (51×51 cm) as the floor. Width beats height: a cockatiel flies in short horizontal bursts
Cage target	24×24×30 in (61×61×76 cm) or wider. Page 5 explains why the sources differ
Bar spacing	1/2 in (13 mm) is the safe figure. Page 5 on why some sources allow more
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C). Drafts and sudden swings matter more than the number
Darkness needed	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted, every night, with a dim night light. Page 7
Body temperature	About 107.1°F (41.8°C). Resting heart rate about 206 bpm, breathing 40 to 50 a minute
Sexual maturity	6 to 12 months
Sexing	Visible in the normal gray after the first molt, one of the few parrots where looking at the bird is enough. Page 16
Handling difficulty	Beginner. Built on trust with a flighted bird, never on restraint. Page 14
Conservation status	Least Concern (IUCN)

Cost overview

Initial setup

The bird runs \$75 to \$250 depending on the color mutation, with normal gray usually cheapest because it is the wild type and needs no selective breeding. A complete first setup lands most buyers at **\$320 to \$860**, and the cage is routinely the biggest single line, often more than the bird. Page 30 itemizes it.

Ongoing

Food, toys and cage upkeep run roughly **\$200 to \$350 a year**, and the annual exam takes that to **\$285 to \$550**, about \$24 to \$46 a month. An avian exam alone is \$85 to \$200 before any testing, and a reproductive emergency runs \$300 to \$800 or more. Bird insurance barely exists, so the emergency fund is you. Page 30 itemizes both.

THE NUMBER THAT SHOULD DRIVE THE DECISION

Not the price. The lifespan. A cockatiel bought for a ten-year-old is very likely still alive when that child finishes college, and the commonest reason one does not reach fifteen is a seed bowl nobody ever changed. If you are not prepared to still be feeding this bird in 2046, buy something else.

THE ONE THING THIS SPECIES IS FAMOUS FOR

Night frights. A cockatiel startled in total darkness thrashes violently inside the cage and can injure a wing, a foot or its face on the bars before you reach the light switch. It is the single most preventable injury in this book, and the fix is a dim night light. Page 7.

Cage size, bar spacing & placement

The purchase that is hardest to undo, and the one number that is a safety limit.

Credible sources give different cage figures and both are printed here rather than averaged. LafeberVet gives a minimum of 20 to 24 in (50 to 60 cm) long and wide for a cockatiel. Care references commonly cite 20×20×30 in (51×51×76 cm) as a minimum, and many keepers aim closer to 24×24×30 in (61×61×76 cm) for comfortable movement. Treat **20×20 in of footprint as the floor** below which a cage is not adequate, and **24×24×30 in or wider as what to actually buy**. Nobody has ever regretted the bigger cage.

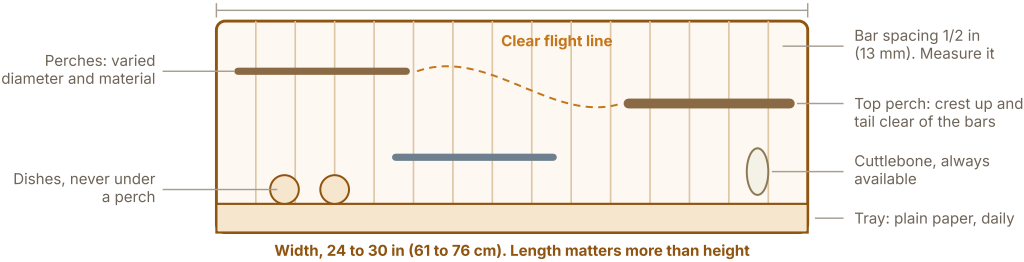
Shape matters as much as volume, and a cockatiel has a long tail to fit inside it. This is a horizontal flyer that crosses open ground in short fast bursts, not a climber, so a tall narrow cage sells you height the bird will not use and a tail it will wear against the bars. Given 30 in of width or 30 in of height at the same price, take the width every time.

BAR SPACING: 1/2 IN (13 MM)

LafeberVet gives 0.5 to 0.75 in (1.3 to 1.9 cm) as the range. Care guidance for pet cockatiels is stricter and gives half an inch or smaller, and that is the figure to build to: a cockatiel's head is small enough that the top of the published range is a genuine entrapment risk, and a trapped bird panics and injures its neck long before you find it. Measure the cage yourself rather than trusting the box. Avoid round cages, which give a bird no corner to settle into, and check the finish: galvanized bars and hardware are a zinc source, covered on page 8.

Where the cage goes

PLACE	WHY
Against a wall, at or near eye level	A cage in open floor space with movement on all sides reads as exposure to a prey animal. One solid side to back into settles a new bird faster than anything else you can do in week one
A room the family actually uses	Cockatiels are flock birds and one kept in a spare room is alone whether or not it has a companion. Page 9
Not the kitchen, ever	Overheated nonstick cookware kills birds, and it is not a rare event. Page 8 gives the temperature and the mechanism
Away from a window that flashes	Headlights sweeping a wall are a classic night fright trigger. If the cage has to sit near a window, cover three sides at night and leave a light on. Page 7
Out of all-day sun and off a draft	A caged bird cannot move out of the sun. Partial sun with shade available is fine; a sunny windowsill is not. Keep the cage off the floor and away from exterior doors and air-conditioning vents



BUY THE CAGE BEFORE THE BIRD

Set it up, fill it, and leave it standing for a few days. It is far easier to find out that the door catch is flimsy or the tray does not slide out with nothing living in it, and a cage that arrives at the same time as the bird gets assembled in a hurry.

Perches, dishes & what to leave out

The inside of the cage does more for the bird than the outside dimensions do.

Perches

A cage furnished with identical dowels loads the same points of the foot all day, every day, which is how pressure sores and foot fatigue start. Give the bird a choice: natural branch, rope, and a variety of diameters, roughly 1/2 to 3/4 in (13 to 19 mm), placed at different heights and far enough apart that crossing the cage takes a real hop or a wingbeat rather than a step.

TYPE	WHAT IT DOES
Natural branch	Irregular diameter along its length, so the foot changes grip constantly. Apple, willow, manzanita and eucalyptus are all used. Unsprayed, scrubbed and dried, and free
Rope perch	Soft and grippy, good for an older bird. Inspect weekly and retire it once it frays: loose fibers wrap around toes, and cockatiels are noted for swallowing them. Page 23
Swing	Worth adding. Cockatiels frequently choose to sleep on one
Cement or mineral perch	One, low down, for nail wear. Never the highest perch, where the bird stands longest
Sandpaper perch covers	Leave them out entirely. They abrade the sole of the foot and do not shorten a nail

Dishes and water

Two food dishes and one water dish, none of them under a perch. Stainless steel is easiest to actually get clean. Cockatiels bathe in the drinking water and foul it fast, so change it daily as a rule and again whenever it looks used. Offer a separate shallow bath daily, in the morning so the feathers dry before night; it keeps the drinking water usable.

Nails: how, not how often

There is no verified interval to print: how often a nail needs doing depends on what the bird stands on, not on a calendar, and rough varied perches wear nails down where smooth dowels do not. Every toenail carries a blood vessel and nerve part way down it, the **quick**, further down the longer the nail has grown. It shows as a pink core on a pale nail and is invisible on a dark one, which is what a flashlight behind the toe is for. Take a little at a time. If you catch it: stay calm, hold the bird securely, pinch the toe side to side above the nail, press styptic powder or cornstarch onto the cut end, and keep the bird off its water dish for a few hours. A first trim, or any bird with nails too dark to read, is a vet or groomer job.

The floor

Plain paper, changed daily. Newspaper, butcher paper or plain paper towel all work. The point of a paper liner is that you can read the droppings off it, which is the cheapest daily health check you have and is covered on page 26. Anything that hides a dropping, corncob, walnut shell, sand or wood chips, defeats that and grows mold underneath.

LEAVE THESE OUT OF THE CAGE

Grit or gravel. Cockatiels hull seed before swallowing the kernel, so they do not need it, and a sick bird will gorge on it and obstruct. **Mirrors**, for a single hen especially, since a mirror is a mate and a mate is a hormonal trigger. **Nest boxes, happy huts and any enclosed dark cavity**, for the same reason: page 17. **Anything galvanized**, which is a zinc source. And **frayed rope, loose threads and unraveling fabric**, which this species eats.

CUTTLEBONE AND A MINERAL BLOCK, PERMANENTLY

Both stay in the cage for the life of the bird. They are a calcium and trace mineral source and a beak surface, and they matter most for a hen, who will pull calcium out of her own skeleton to build an eggshell if the diet does not supply it. Page 18 on what that leads to.

Light, sleep & night frights

Day length is the lever the whole hormonal section turns on, and darkness is where this species gets hurt.

A cockatiel needs **10 to 12 hours of uninterrupted darkness every night**. Not a dim room: dark, quiet, and undisturbed. A bird living in a lit living room until midnight is being told the days are long, and long days are a breeding signal. Almost everything on pages 17 and 18 traces back to a photoperiod nobody was managing.

If the family room stays lit and loud, the answer is a second smaller cage in a quiet room used only for sleeping, moved to at the same time each night. A cage cover works if the room genuinely goes quiet. What does not work is deciding the bird will adjust.

NIGHT FRIGHTS, AND THE TWO-DOLLAR FIX

Cockatiels are far more prone than most parrots to thrashing panics in the dark. A car headlight sweeping the wall, a moth on the window, a smoke alarm chirp, and the bird explodes off the perch into the bars. Broken blood feathers, a bleeding cere, a damaged wing and a foot caught in a toy are all normal outcomes. Birds do not see in the dark, which is why a startled cockatiel cannot find a perch.

Leave a dim night light on in the room. Just enough to dispel the dark, not enough to shorten the night. Do not black the cage out completely: a cover on three sides and part of the top gives security while leaving the bird able to see where it is. If a night fright happens anyway, turn a light on and talk to the bird quietly until it settles back onto a perch. Then check it over for blood before you go back to bed.

SETTING	NUMBER
Darkness, normal routine	10 to 12 hours , uninterrupted, same times every night
Light, to break a laying cycle	8 hours of light a day , which is 16 hours of dark; LafeberVet gives the same intervention as 8 to 10 hours. An intervention, run under vet advice, not a permanent setting. Merck names a photoperiod over 12 hours as a documented risk factor for excessive laying. Page 17
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C). Cockatiels tolerate more than that, but drafts and fast swings are what cause problems
Daylight	Natural indirect daylight, or a full-spectrum lamp on a timer. Window glass filters most UVB, so a sunny windowsill is not a UVB source, only a heat trap

THE DUST, AND YOUR OWN LUNGS

Cockatiels are a powder-down species; Merck names them with cockatoos as heavy producers of the keratin dust that films a room. That is normal. Prolonged exposure to avian proteins in it and in dried droppings can cause hypersensitivity pneumonitis, **bird fancier's lung**: the NHLBI lists pet birds in the home as a risk factor, usually diagnosed between 50 and 70, with lung fibrosis at the serious end. It is uncommon. Run a HEPA purifier in the room, offer a bath daily, damp-wipe rather than dry-dust, keep the cage out of the bedroom, and **tell your doctor you keep a parrot** if you get a cough that does not behave like a cold.

Why sleep is a health page, not a lighting note

A sleep-deprived cockatiel is a louder, bitier, more anxious cockatiel, and sleep debt is one of the more common invisible drivers behind feather plucking on page 24. It is also the cheapest thing in this book to fix. Before you change the diet, buy a toy, or call a behaviorist about a screaming bird, count the hours of real darkness it is actually getting. It is very often nine.

A TREAT THIRTY MINUTES BEFORE LIGHTS OUT

A small predictable snack shortly before the room goes dark gives the bird a reason to settle rather than to be startled by the change, and it puts food in a small bird before its longest fast of the day. Make it part of the routine on page 33.

Household hazards & bird-proofing

The most important page in this package. A bird's lungs make ordinary household air lethal.

A bird's respiratory system is built to extract oxygen on a continuous one-way flow, which is what makes flight possible and what makes airborne poisons far more dangerous to a cockatiel than to you. Fumes that make a person cough kill a 90 g bird. Nothing else on this list matters if this page is wrong.

PTFE: THE ONE THAT KILLS WITH NO WARNING

Nonstick cookware releases polytetrafluoroethylene gas when overheated to about **536°F (280°C)**, which an empty or forgotten pan reaches in minutes. The gas causes direct caustic damage to the lung, and the Merck Veterinary Manual notes that **acute death is often the only clinical sign**. Documented cases describe multiple birds dead within half an hour of a single overheated pan, and the fumes travel: a bird in another room is not safe.

Cookware is not the only source. Merck also lists **irons and ironing board covers, some self-cleaning ovens, heating elements in some reverse-cycle heat pumps, and some heat lamps**. If a bird lives in the house, the practical answer is to replace nonstick pans with stainless steel or cast iron, never run an oven's self-clean cycle, and keep the cage out of the kitchen entirely.

HAZARD	WHERE IT IS	WHAT IT DOES
Zinc	Galvanized toys, chains, mesh, bells, keys, pennies after 1982. Electroplated galvanizing is considered safe; hot-dipped, the commoner kind, leaches zinc with no flake swallowed	Anorexia, gut disease, weakness, regurgitation, excessive drinking and urination. Chelated by a vet
Lead	Blinds, costume jewelry, mirror backings, bird toys, hardware cloth, curtain weights. It tastes sweet, so a bird that finds it keeps chewing	Weight loss, regurgitation, diarrhea, weakness, incoordination, seizures, blindness. Treatable, and worth catching early
Aerosols and smoke	Carpet fresheners, perfumes, deodorizers, votive candles, plastics melted or burned in a microwave, new heating duct systems, tobacco smoke	Irritant to fatal depending on dose. Ventilate before you spray, and never spray in the bird's room
Open water	Full sinks, toilets, pans on the stove, uncovered aquariums	A wet cockatiel cannot climb out of a smooth basin. Lids down, sinks emptied
Windows and mirrors	Anywhere a flighted bird has a clear run	Collision injuries. Blinds half drawn during out-of-cage time
The other pets	Cats and dogs	A cat's mouth carries <i>Pasteurella</i> . Any cat contact is a same-day vet visit even with no visible wound
Ceiling fans and hobs	On, during free flight	Both are fatal and both are avoidable by switching them off first

Houseplants and food left out

A flighted cockatiel lands on things and tastes them. Avocado is the one most consistently flagged: persin, in every part of the plant, respiratory distress about 12 hours after eating it, death possible inside two days. Chocolate, caffeine and alcohol follow; page 12 has the list. Keep a CO detector in any room with gas heat or a gas range. Assume any houseplant is on the table until you have checked it, and clear the counter before the bird comes out, because a cockatiel will find the wine glass.

THE FIVE-MINUTE PRE-FLIGHT CHECK

Windows and doors shut. Blinds partly drawn. Ceiling fan off. Stove off and pans away. Toilet lids down and sinks empty. Other pets out of the room. Candles out. Do it in the same order every time and it becomes automatic, which is the point.

One cockatiel or two, and the whistling trade-off

The decision that shapes everything else, and it is not the one most buyers think it is.

Cockatiels are flock birds. In the wild they are essentially never alone, and a bird kept singly has to get that flock from you. That is entirely possible, and it produces the tame, whistling, shoulder-riding cockatiel most people picture. It is also a real daily commitment: a solo bird needs an hour or more out of the cage and real attention every day, for the next fifteen years. A cockatiel that does not get it becomes chronically stressed, and that shows up as screaming, feather damage and illness rather than as sulking.

	ONE BIRD	A PAIR
Tameness	Bonds hard to people, usually to one person. The tamest cockatiels are single birds	Bonds to each other first. Still handleable, rarely as intensely attached
Whistling and talking	Males in a quiet house learn tunes and sometimes words. This is largely a single-male phenomenon	Much less likely to pick up human whistles. They already have someone to talk to
Your time	An hour or more out of the cage daily, with you, indefinitely	Far more forgiving of an unpredictable schedule
Cage	The floor on page 5	Wider, and two of everything: perches, dishes, toys
Hormones	No breeding, but a lone hen still lays, so no mirror and no cavity	Two cocks bring no eggs. A mixed pair with a cavity is a breeding setup whether or not you meant one. Page 17
Cost	Baseline	Roughly 1.6 to 1.8 times, not double. Page 30

ANSWER THIS HONESTLY FIRST

Will this bird get an hour or more out of the cage with you every day, on the bad weeks as well as the good ones? If yes, one bird gives you the better pet and no breeding pair to manage. If the honest answer is "some days," get two. A pair of cockatiels that entertain each other is a far kinder outcome than a single bird waiting alone for a person who is busy, and the difference in how tame they are is smaller than people expect.

If you go with two

Two cocks are the easiest pairing and the only one with no eggs. Two hens still lay, since a hen needs no male to do it. A mixed pair will breed given any cavity at all, so if you want a mixed pair without chicks, the rule is no nest box, no happy hut, no dark enclosed anything, and a photoperiod you actually control. Never simply put a new bird straight into the cage of an established one: page 27 covers the quarantine period and the introduction.

THE TALKING QUESTION, ANSWERED HONESTLY

Cockatiels are whistlers far more than talkers. Males learn and endlessly repeat melodies, and some pick up short phrases; hens rarely do either to any degree. Buying a cockatiel specifically to get a talking bird is a bad bet, and a bird bought for a trick it may never perform is a bird at risk of being rehomed. Buy it for the whistling and the company, and treat words as a bonus.

Diet: pellets, seed & converting a seed eater

The single biggest lever on how long this bird lives. Everything in section 03 traces back here.

VCA gives the target as **75 to 80% formulated pellets, 20 to 25% fresh vegetables and fruit**, and seed as a very small part of the diet rather than the base of it. That is the whole prescription. A seed mix is high in fat and carbohydrate and deficient in protein, vitamin A, and calcium, and a bird left to choose picks the sunflower and millet and leaves the rest, so the diet the bird actually eats is worse than the one on the label.

THIS IS NOT A PREFERENCE, IT IS THE DISEASE LIST

Hypovitaminosis A, calcium deficiency, obesity and fatty liver disease all come from a seed bowl, and Merck notes that even a half-seed, half-pellet diet leaves a bird vitamin A deficient. Pages 20 and 18 are the consequences. If you change one thing after reading this book, change this.

How the day actually works

Cockatiels are free-choice eaters, not meal eaters. They have a fast metabolism and graze all day, so refresh the pellet bowl in the morning when the bird is hungriest and top it up rather than letting it sit empty. Fresh produce goes in daily and comes out after about two hours before it spoils. Treats and table food stay under roughly 10% of the weekly diet, and portions are smaller than they look: a teaspoon to a cockatiel is about what a dinner plate is to you.

Converting a seed eater, five methods

VCA is blunt that this can take **days, weeks or months**. There is no fast version, and none of these is a hunger strike. Pick one, or run several together.

METHOD	HOW
Morning first	Offer pellets alone first thing, when the bird is hungriest, and put the seed back later in the day
Mix and shift	Mix pellets into the seed and slowly decrease the seed share over weeks
Spread it flat	Scatter pellets on a flat surface or a shallow tray, which reads as ground feeding to a grass-seed eater
Grind it in	Grind pellets to powder over a moist food, then increase the chunk size week by week
Eat with the bird	Cockatiels are social feeders. Sitting beside the cage eating the same vegetable, visibly, converts more birds than any product does

Withdraw the seed only once the bird is reliably eating pellets and produce, and **weigh it through the change**, on the gram scale from page 16. More than 1 to 2% of body weight lost in a week means the change is running too fast, so slow it down. A bird that keeps losing is not converting, it is starving.

MILLET, HONEY STICKS AND GRIT

Millet spray is the highest-value treat you own and the easiest thing to overfeed; keep it for training and hand-taming rather than the cage. VCA describes honey sticks plainly as seeds stuck together with sugar and honey, and similarly nutrient-deficient. And **do not offer grit**: cockatiels hull the seed before swallowing the kernel, so they have no use for it, and a sick bird will overeat it and obstruct.

SUPPLEMENTS

A bird genuinely eating 75 to 80% pellets does not need added vitamins or minerals; the pellet is already fortified and stacking supplements on top can do harm. A bird still on seed, or a laying hen, is the exception, and that is a conversation with your vet rather than a jar off a shelf. The cuttlebone stays in either way.

Safe vegetables, greens & herbs

The 20 to 25% of the diet that is not pellets, and the part that fixes vitamin A.

Vegetables are where a cockatiel gets the vitamin A its ancestors got from fresh growing seed heads, and vitamin A deficiency is the commonest nutritional disease in pet birds. The rule that does the work is simple: **dark green and dark orange**. Pale, watery vegetables are not harmful, they are just close to empty, and they take up room in a small bird's day.

VEGETABLE	TIER	NOTES
Kale, chard, dandelion greens	STAPLE	The best of the greens. Wash well, chop small, offer daily
Carrot, grated or in coins	STAPLE	Dense in vitamin A precursors. Raw is fine and holds up better in the cage
Cooked sweet potato	STAPLE	Cooked and cooled, never raw. A reliable favorite with birds refusing everything else
Bell peppers, any color	STAPLE	Seeds and all. The capsaicin question does not arise; birds do not register heat the way mammals do, but sweet peppers are the ones to use
Broccoli, florets and leaf	STAPLE	Raw or lightly steamed. Good for shredding as well as eating
Pumpkin and winter squash	STAPLE	Cooked. Seeds are fine in small amounts and make good foraging
Zucchini, snap peas, green beans	REGULAR	Well accepted, lower in vitamin A than the list above. Good variety rather than good nutrition
Romaine and other leaf lettuce	REGULAR	Fine, and mostly water. Do not let it crowd out the dark greens
Sweetcorn	SPARING	Eagerly eaten, high in sugar and starch. A treat, not a vegetable serving
Iceberg lettuce, celery	SKIP	Not toxic, close to nutritionally empty, and iceberg can loosen droppings enough to worry you unnecessarily
Onion, garlic, leek, chive	NEVER	Onion and garlic are linked to a serious blood disorder in birds. Page 12

Getting a refuser to eat them

Many cockatiels reject vegetables on sight for weeks. Nothing about that is unusual and none of it means the bird dislikes the food; a cockatiel decides what is food by watching its flock eat it. What works, in rough order:

- **Eat it in front of the bird**, obviously and with some enthusiasm, from your own plate. This is the single most effective trick with this species
- **Change the format, not the food**. A refused chunk of carrot gets eaten grated, or woven through the cage bars, or clipped to a skewer
- **Offer it first thing**, before the pellet bowl goes in
- **Chop it into the size of the pellets** the bird already accepts, and mix
- **Keep offering**. Twenty refusals then acceptance is a normal pattern, not a failure

HERBS COUNT, AND THEY ARE CHEAP

Parsley, cilantro, basil, dill and mint are all safe and all get shredded with enthusiasm. A supermarket herb pot on the windowsill gives fresh greens for weeks and doubles as destructible enrichment. Rinse anything you did not grow, and never use plants sprayed for pests.

TWO HOURS, THEN OUT

Fresh food is a bacterial growth medium at room temperature. Put it in, let the bird work on it, and take the remains out after about two hours. A dish of yesterday's vegetables is a health risk, not a leftover.

Fruit, treats & the never-feed list

The smaller half of the fresh share, and the short list that is genuinely toxic.

Fruit sits inside the same 20 to 25% as the vegetables, not on top of it, and it should be the smaller part. It is mostly sugar and water, cockatiels love it, and a bird filling up on banana is a bird not eating kale. Wash everything, cut it small, and remove pits and apple seeds.

FRUIT	TIER	NOTES
Berries: blueberry, strawberry, raspberry	BEST	Lower sugar, easy to portion, and they color the droppings red or purple for a day, which is normal. Page 26
Papaya, mango, melon, apricot	BEST	The vitamin A end of the fruit list
Apple, pear, peach	REGULAR	Seeds and pits out. Apple seeds and stone-fruit pits release cyanide-related compounds. The flesh is fine
Banana, grape	SPARING	High sugar, universally popular. A treat-sized piece, not a serving
Dried fruit	SPARING	Concentrated sugar. Check for sulfite preservatives and use a piece the size of the bird's eye
Cooked egg, lean meat, fish, cheese	SPARING	Small amounts are fine and useful for a molting or laying bird. Nothing processed, salted or seasoned
Millet spray	TRAINING ONLY	The most effective training reward you have. Off the cage, in your hand, for a reason

NEVER, AT ANY QUANTITY

Avocado, which is the food flagged most consistently across veterinary sources and is genuinely fatal to birds. **Chocolate. Caffeine.** Coffee, tea, energy drinks. **Alcohol. Onion and garlic**, linked to a serious blood disorder. **Fruit pits and apple seeds. Salt, and salted human snacks**, at 90 g of bird. And anything sugar-free containing **xylitol**, which has no established safe dose in birds and is not worth finding out about.

Treats, and the portion problem

Treats should stay under about 10% of the weekly diet, and the practical failure is not what people give but how much. A cockatiel weighs about 90 g. A level teaspoon of anything is a substantial meal, a whole millet spray is a day's calories, and half a grape is a portion. Break treats down before they go in, and give them by hand where possible, so the treat buys you training as well as calories. Page 14.

THE SEED DISH IS A TREAT DISH NOW

Once the bird is converted, the way to keep seed in the picture without undoing the work is to stop putting it in a bowl. Use it as the reward in a foraging toy, or as the payment in a training session on page 13. Same seed, a tenth of the quantity, and the bird has to work for it, which is the point.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Cockatiels finally have research of their own, and it points at the food bowl.

Two studies now exist on cockatiel enrichment specifically, a 2020 paper on cockatiel behavior in aviaries and a 2025 paper concluding that environmental enrichment improves behavior and welfare in captive cockatiels, **with reduced feather-damaging behavior singled out as the outcome**. Most parrot enrichment research has gone to larger or endangered species, so a bird kept in millions of homes was studied late.

The structural finding across parrots is the one to act on. Food offered in a bowl produces **foraging times of well under an hour a day**, and abnormal repetitive behavior fills the rest. That is not a small change to the routine, it is most of the bird's waking behavior missing.

Priority order, highest value first

- 1. **Move the food out of the bowl.** Deliver part of the daily ration through things that have to be worked at. Start easy: a bird that has only ever been bowl-fed does not know food is inside a device, so stage one is food sitting visibly on top of a toy, not hidden inside it
- 2. **Company**, whether a compatible bird or a real daily routine with you. Page 9
- 3. **Varied perch diameters and materials.** A foot health intervention and a choice intervention at once. Page 6
- 4. **Shreddable, destructible material, rotated.** Paper, softwood, palm, untreated natural fiber. Material that survives the week has not done its job
- 5. **A bath offered daily**, in the morning so the feathers dry by night
- 6. **An hour or more out of the cage** daily, in a proofed room. Page 8
- 7. **Novel objects**, last. They are the least important thing on this list and the thing most often bought first

The mistakes that actually cost the bird

MISTAKE	WHAT IT LEADS TO
A seed bowl, left as the base diet	Vitamin A deficiency, fatty liver, a shorter life. Page 20
No night light	An avoidable injury from a night fright. Page 7
A cage in a spare room	Chronic stress in a flock animal, then screaming and plucking. Page 24
A happy hut, nest box or dark cavity	A hormonal hen and a laying cycle you then have to break. Page 17
A tall narrow cage	Unused height, a worn tail, and no flight line. Page 5
Treating a solved puzzle as enrichment	A toy the bird finished in March is furniture by April. Rotate
Buying toys instead of giving time	Nothing in a cage substitutes for the flock. Enrichment is partly you
Assuming plucking is behavioral	It is a vet visit first, every time. Page 24

TRAINING IS ENRICHMENT, AND IT IS FREE

Five minutes twice a day with a millet reward: target training, step up, a recall to the hand, and stepping onto a portable perch. It costs nothing, it is mentally harder work for the bird than any toy, and it produces a cockatiel you can get back into a cage on a bad evening. Keep the sessions short and stop while the bird still wants more.

Handling, taming & reading the crest

Trust first, technique second. The crest tells you which one you are on.

The first two weeks: do nothing

A new cockatiel needs **7 to 14 days to settle before any handling attempt**. Feed it, change the water, talk to it, sit near the cage and read out loud, and otherwise leave it alone. Rushing this is the commonest reason a bird takes months to tame instead of weeks, because everything you do in week one teaches the bird whether hands are safe.

The progression

1. Sit beside the cage at the bird's level and talk softly. No hands
2. Offer millet *through* the bars until the bird takes it without backing off
3. Rest a still hand inside the cage, holding the millet, and wait. Do not follow the bird
4. Move the millet closer to your hand each session until the bird has to stand on you to reach it
5. Introduce the step-up cue, then practice it away from the cage where the bird is less territorial

Sessions of **10 to 15 minutes** are plenty, and the bird's comfort sets the pace, not a schedule. Going back a step after a bad session costs one day. Pushing through a bad session costs a week.

OFFER A FLAT PALM, NOT A FINGER

Fingers pointing down, thumb tucked in, so the bird steps onto a flat surface, or use a handheld perch. A single upright finger is an awkward thing to grip and most birds bite it rather than stand on it. And **never chase a loose cockatiel to catch it**: a panicked bird can fly into a window hard enough to injure itself or exhaust itself into collapse, and forcing the moment costs you weeks of trust for one evening's convenience.

Reading the crest

The crest tracks mood in a general way, so read it alongside posture and feather fluff. Reading it before a bite is one of the more useful skills with an unfamiliar bird.

CREST	WHAT IT MEANS
Upright and relaxed, slightly curved	Calm curiosity. Carry on
Held back, flat but loose, body soft	Content. Often paired with beak grinding, which is a sleepy contentment sound
Flattened tight to the head, body rigid	Fear or aggression. Back off now
Straight up and stiff, held forward	Startled alertness. Something changed. Find out what before you reach in

Stress signals, stop and wait

Hissing. A flattened or agitated crest. Lunging. Tail flicking. Fluffed feathers with rapid breathing. Scrambling to the far side of the cage. Neck stretching to keep you in view.

Comfort signals, carry on

Soft chirping. Preening while you are there. Beak grinding. A relaxed upright crest. Stretching one wing and leg together. Sleeping on one foot in your presence.

WHERE NOT TO TOUCH A COCKATIEL

Head and neck only. Stroking the back, under the wings, or around the vent mimics a mate and is a direct hormonal trigger, which is how an affectionate handling routine turns into the egg problem on page 17. This applies to cocks as well as hens. Scratch the head, leave the body alone.

Wing clipping & flight

You will be asked about this in week one, usually by whoever is selling the trim. Here is both sides.

Wing clipping means shortening some of the primary flight feathers so the bird cannot gain height. It is not permanent: the cut feathers are dead structures and they are replaced at the next molt, so a clip lasts one molt cycle. There is no fixed interval to quote: Merck notes molt timing varies with nutrition, daylight and humidity, so check the wings rather than the calendar. It is also not a behavior tool. A clip can leave a bird more reliant on you and more accepting of a hand, but that is a bird less able to leave, not a trained one, and it fixes no biting, screaming or hormonal problem.

THE CASE FOR CLIPPING	THE CASE AGAINST
Removes the escape risk from an open door or window	The same risk is removed by closing the door. A clipped bird startled outdoors can still catch a gust and go, and it cannot fly back
Removes the collision risk from windows and mirrors in a new home	Flight is the bird's main exercise. Clipped birds gain weight and lose muscle, and both feed the pages in section 03
Makes handling an untamed bird easier in the first weeks	Handling built on a bird that cannot leave is compliance, not trust. Page 14 builds the real thing
Reduces the risk in a home with a stove, a fish tank or a dog	A clipped bird lands hard. Keel injuries and split skin just behind the vent are the common consequence, especially on hard floors

BLOOD FEATHERS, AND WHY A TRIM IS NOT A HAIRCUT

A growing feather has a live blood supply in its shaft and looks dark and full near the base. **Cut one and it bleeds, sometimes badly enough to matter in a 90 g bird.** Only fully mature feathers are ever trimmed, and knowing the difference is the whole skill. Merck's method is four to seven of the outermost primaries on both wings, cut below the coverts that overlay them, with the secondaries closer to the body left alone, because those are what let a bird slow down and land. If you clip, an avian vet or an experienced groomer does it, and you watch the first time. Do not attempt a first clip yourself off a video.

If it is done, what a correct clip leaves

A correct trim leaves the bird able to glide down to the floor under control from a standing perch, symmetrically on both wings so it does not spiral. It does not leave a bird that drops like a stone, and it never removes every primary. Ask for a light, symmetrical trim and check the landing before you leave.

The honest recommendation

For most households, a flighted cockatiel in a bird-proofed room is the better outcome, and the effort goes into the pre-flight check on page 8 rather than into the bird. Clipping is defensible in a specific and temporary situation, a first month with an untamed bird, a house with young children, an owner who genuinely cannot secure the doors, and in those cases it is a decision to revisit at the next molt rather than a permanent policy.

TRAIN A RECALL EITHER WAY

A cockatiel that flies to your hand on cue is safer than a clipped one, because you can retrieve it from anywhere in the room without a chase. Millet, a short distance, a consistent cue, twice a day. It is the single most useful behavior in this book, built a little more distance at a time.

Sexing, weight & body condition

One of the few parrots you can sex by looking, and the one number you should track daily.

Sexing the normal gray

Cockatiels are visibly dimorphic in the wild-type gray once the bird has been through its **first molt**, which is why a young bird of either sex looks like a hen. After it:

	COCK	HEN
Face	Bright yellow forehead, throat, crest and cheeks, with vivid orange ear patches	Much less yellow, a duller face, and paler orange cheeks
Under the wing	Solid, unmarked plumage	A barred pattern underneath the wings
Tail	Plain underside	Barred or spotted underside
Voice	Whistles, learns tunes, sometimes words	Rarely whistles tunes to any degree

This does not transfer to the mutations. Lutino, pied, whiteface, albino and pearl birds can be impossible to sex on appearance, and a pied bird may retain hen-type barring for life. Where it matters, and it matters for anything on pages 17 and 18, **a DNA test on a blood spot or a plucked feather is the actual answer** and costs about the same as a bag of pellets.

WHY YOU NEED TO KNOW

Because a hen can lay without a mate, and chronic laying is the commonest serious problem in this species. An owner who thinks their bird is a cock is an owner who does not notice a laying cycle starting.

Weight is this species' vital sign

A bird hides illness until it cannot, but it cannot hide a falling weight. A **digital kitchen scale reading in 1 g steps** costs less than a bag of pellets and is the single most useful piece of equipment you will buy. Glue or tape a short perch to the pan, weigh the bird at the same time each day, before breakfast, and write it on page 36.

READING	WHAT IT MEANS
80 to 125 g, average about 90 g	The published range. Your own bird's stable number is what matters, not where it sits in the range
Day-to-day variation of 2 to 3 g	Normal. Food in the crop, a dropping just passed
A steady fall over a week	Investigate. In a diet change, over 1 to 2% a week means slow down. In a settled bird it is a vet call
Roughly 10% below baseline	Call the vet. In a 90 g bird that is 9 g, which is nothing on a bathroom scale and everything to the bird
Roughly 20% above ideal	Merck's working definition of obesity in a bird. Page 20

Feeling the keel

The keel is the ridge of breastbone running down the front of the bird. Rest a finger either side of it during a normal head scratch.

- **Sharp and prominent, muscle falling away either side:** underweight. Common in a bird that has been converting too fast, or is sick
- **Ridge easily felt, muscle rounded and full to each side:** what you want
- **Keel hard to find, chest convex, a groove down the middle:** overweight. Diet and flight, not a crash diet

ESTABLISH THE BASELINE IN WEEK ONE

Weigh the bird every day for the first two weeks and record it. Those two weeks of numbers are what make every future reading meaningful, and they are the thing owners wish they had when something looks off in year three.

Hens, hormones & chronic egg laying

VCA notes reproductive problems are even more common in cockatiels than in budgies. This is the page that prevents them.

A cockatiel hen will lay eggs with no male present and no intention on your part. She does it because the environment told her to, and every clutch costs her calcium she pulls out of her own skeleton. **Chronic egg laying** is laying clutch after clutch, out of season, and it ends in metabolic bone disease, weakness, and the emergency on page 18. It is close to entirely preventable, and the levers are environmental rather than medical.

The trigger list, and what to do about each

TRIGGER	REMOVE IT
Long days	The main lever. 10 to 12 hours of darkness normally; to break a cycle, cut to 8 hours of light a day under vet advice. Page 7
Any dark enclosed cavity	Nest box, happy hut, tent, a cardboard box, the space behind the sofa, a kitchen drawer she found. All of it goes
Petting the back, wings or vent	Head and neck only, by everyone in the house. Page 14
A mirror, or a bonded toy	Out. To a lone hen a mirror is a mate
Shredding material and soft nesting substrate	Restrict paper shredding during a hormonal period, and keep the tray liner out of reach
Rich, abundant, constant food	Plenty reads as a good breeding season. Keep portions measured, keep treats rare, and move food into foraging toys
Rearranging nothing	Moving the cage to a different wall and rearranging perches disrupts a territory she has decided is a nest site

DO NOT REMOVE THE EGGS

This is the counterintuitive one and it is the one owners get wrong. Pulling eggs as they appear tells the hen the clutch has failed and she lays a replacement, which is exactly how chronic laying starts. **Leave the clutch alone and let her sit.** A cockatiel clutch is 3 to 8 eggs, average 5, and incubation runs 19 to 21 days, which is this species' own figure from LafeberVet rather than the 21 to 28 days quoted as a general parrot range, so a hen allowed to sit typically gives up after roughly three weeks and stops. When she gives up, take the eggs away gradually, one every day or two, since clearing them at once can restart the cycle. Dummy eggs in place of real ones mean nothing rots. Sitting on a clutch costs her far less than laying four more.

Support a laying hen

- **Calcium, permanently available.** Cuttlebone and a mineral block in the cage, not offered occasionally. A hen on a seed diet is a hen in calcium debt
- **Vitamin D3**, which she needs to use the calcium. This is another reason the diet on page 10 is a pellet diet
- **Weigh her daily** through a laying period. Page 16
- **Extra protein** while she is laying: a little cooked egg is traditional and effective

WHEN THE ENVIRONMENT IS NOT ENOUGH

A hen who keeps laying after everything above has been done needs an avian vet, not another month of adjustments. Hormone therapy exists, in the form of injections or implants, and it is used exactly for this. Ask for it before she is depleted rather than after the first egg-binding episode.

Egg binding

A decision you make in ten minutes, not a condition you monitor. Read this before it happens.

Egg binding is a hen unable to pass an egg. VCA names cockatiels among the small birds most often affected, and states plainly that **small birds can die within a few hours of becoming egg-bound**, from compromised circulation and pressure on the airways. There is no wait-and-see version of this page.

SIGNS, ROUGHLY IN THE ORDER THEY APPEAR

Weakness, and sitting low or on the cage floor rather than perching. **Straining**, as if trying to pass a dropping, often repeatedly and with nothing produced. A visibly swollen or firm lower abdomen. Fluffed feathers, wide stance, labored breathing. Sometimes an egg visible at the vent, or tissue prolapsing out of it. In late cases, **leg weakness or paralysis** on one or both sides, from the egg pressing on the nerves. And VCA's marker, which stands on its own before any of the rest appears: **no egg passed in 48 hours** by a hen you know is laying.

Any of these is a same-day emergency call. Not tomorrow morning.

Why it happens

CAUSE	DETAIL
Low calcium	The commonest reason. Calcium is what makes the oviduct contract, so a depleted hen cannot push. Seed diets are deficient in calcium, selenium, and vitamins D and E
Obesity and lack of exercise	Both from the same high-fat seed diet. Page 20
Chronic laying	Each clutch depletes her further, so the risk rises with every one. Page 17
A first clutch, or an old hen	Both carry higher risk
An oversized or misshapen egg	Often itself a nutritional problem: soft-shelled and shell-less eggs point straight back at calcium
Cold, or no suitable place to lay	An environmental contribution rather than a cause on its own

What the vet will do

Supplemental heat, injectable fluids, calcium and vitamin D3 are the first-line supportive treatment, and many hens pass the egg once those are on board. Oxytocin may be given to stimulate contraction. If that fails, the egg may be lubricated and eased out, or collapsed by aspirating its contents through a needle so the shell can be removed in pieces. Surgery, a salpingohysterectomy, is the last resort and is also the permanent solution for a hen who binds repeatedly.

WHAT YOU CAN DO IN THE CAR

Keep her **warm** and quiet in a small carrier, around **80°F (27°C)** with a covered heat source she cannot touch directly, and get moving. That is the top of the 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C) range for a sick bird, where birds recover and eat best, and where LafeberVet's 80 to 90°F (27 to 32°C) range for supplemental heat begins. Warmth and humidity are genuinely supportive, but back off if she shows flat sleek feathers, wings held out, or open-mouth breathing, which mean she is too hot. Do **not** try to pull, squeeze or manipulate the egg: the shell breaks inside her, and that turns a treatable emergency into a surgical one. Do not give calcium orally to a collapsed bird.

PREVENTION IS FOUR THINGS

A pellet diet, a permanent cuttlebone, 10 to 12 hours of darkness, and no cavities. That is it. Every hen this happens to is a hen who was missing at least one of them, and the four together cost roughly nothing.

Health red flags & what to tell the vet

A cockatiel that looks sick has been sick for a while. That is the whole problem.

Wild cockatiels live in flocks where a predator picks the bird that looks weakest, so masking illness is hardwired rather than chosen. By the time a pet cockatiel visibly stops coping, the illness is usually well advanced. This is why the weight log on page 16 and the droppings check on page 26 matter: they see the problem before the bird lets you.

SAME-DAY CALL, NO WAITING

Any **difficulty breathing**: tail bobbing with each breath, open-mouth breathing, a clicking or wheezing sound, or a change in voice. **Bleeding** from anywhere. **Sitting on the cage floor** instead of perching. **Discharge** from eyes, nostrils or mouth. **Straining**, in a hen especially: page 18. Fluffed and unresponsive with both feet down. A fall, a cat contact of any kind, or contact with a hot surface. Nothing on this list improves overnight.

Call within 24 hours

- A sustained drop in appetite, especially alongside anything else here
- Any change in droppings that persists beyond about 24 hours. Page 26
- Weight down roughly 10% from the bird's own baseline
- Vomiting, which sticks to the face and chest feathers and is not the same as the deliberate courtship regurgitation onto a toy or a mirror
- New feather damage, bald patches, or obsessive preening of one spot. Page 24
- Lameness or an unwillingness to bear weight on one leg
- Sleeping far more than usual, or sleeping fluffed on two feet rather than resting on one
- Sneezing more than occasionally, or a wet or stained cere

The normal numbers, for reference

MEASURE	NORMAL IN A COCKATIEL
Body temperature	About 107.1°F (41.8°C). Much higher than a mammal, and not something to take at home
Resting heart rate	About 206 beats per minute
Respiratory rate	40 to 50 breaths a minute at rest, with no tail movement
Weight	80 to 125 g, average about 90. Your bird's own baseline is the real number
Droppings	About one every 20 to 30 minutes while awake, formed, with distinct white urates

What to tell the vet, written down before you call

An avian consultation is short and expensive, and the history does most of the diagnostic work. Have these ready:

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Today's weight, and the baseline from page 36 | ☐ Whether it is a hen, and whether it has ever laid |
| ☐ Exactly what the bird eats, by share, not by brand | ☐ Any new bird, new house, or new person |
| ☐ When the signs started, and what changed that week | ☐ Nonstick cookware, candles, aerosols, or a new floor |
| ☐ Hours of darkness it actually gets | ☐ A photo of the droppings on the paper liner |

FIND THE VET BEFORE YOU NEED ONE

Avian practice is a specialty and the nearest one may be an hour away. Call in week one, ask whether they see cockatiels, ask what their emergency arrangement is after hours, and write both numbers on page 29. Doing this on the night it matters is how birds are lost.

Vitamin A, calcium & fatty liver

One cause, three diseases. This page is what a seed bowl actually buys.

Hypovitaminosis A

The commonest nutritional disease in pet birds, and Merck is specific that it is not only all-seed diets that cause it: **even a diet of half seed and half pellets leaves a bird deficient**. Vitamin A maintains the lining of the airways, mouth and eyes, so a deficient bird loses its first line of defense against infection, which is why so many respiratory cases on page 21 are nutritional underneath.

SIGN	WHAT YOU SEE
Airway and sinus	Nasal discharge, sneezing, swelling around the eye, conjunctivitis, labored breathing
Mouth	White plaques inside the mouth and around the eyes, and loss of the normal papillae on the roof of the mouth. Your vet looks for this specifically
Kidneys	Excessive drinking and excessive urination, which shows on the paper as a wet ring
Feathers	Poor feather quality, and feather picking. Page 24
Appetite	Anorexia, often the last sign rather than the first

Treatment is injectable vitamin A given by a vet in acute cases, alongside treating any secondary infection, but the actual fix is the diet conversion on page 10 and the dark orange and dark green vegetables on page 11.

Calcium deficiency

Calcium runs through this species by a different route than in most parrots: not through a hypocalcemia syndrome, which Merck highlights in African greys rather than cockatiels, but through **eggs**. A laying hen mobilizes calcium out of her own skeleton to build shells, and on a seed diet she never replaces it. Signs of depletion are weakness, incoordination, tremors, depression, seizures, and fractures that happen from nothing. In a breeding hen it shows first as **thin-shelled, soft or shell-less eggs**, which is the warning that egg binding on page 18 is next.

Prevention is a permanent cuttlebone and mineral block, a pellet diet that carries vitamin D3 so the calcium can be used, and controlling laying at all. Page 17.

Obesity and hepatic lipidosis

A high-fat seed diet plus a cage-bound bird produces obesity, and obesity in a bird means fat deposited in and around the liver. Merck's working figure for obesity is roughly **20% over ideal weight**, which in a 90 g cockatiel is about 18 g and is invisible without the scale on page 16. Fat accumulation in the abdomen presses on the air sacs, so the first thing many owners notice is that the bird gets breathless crossing the room, or goes lame.

FATTY LIVER DISEASE IS QUIET UNTIL IT IS NOT

A bird with hepatic lipidosis may show nothing for a long time, then present with a distended abdomen, labored breathing, poor feather quality, or overgrown, soft or oddly colored beak and nail keratin, which is a genuinely useful early sign because you can see it during a head scratch. It is managed by a vet with a controlled diet change. **Do not crash-diet a fat bird yourself**. Rapid weight loss in a bird mobilizes fat into a liver that is already struggling and can kill it.

THE WHOLE PREVENTION PLAN, IN ONE LINE

Pellets at 75 to 80%, dark vegetables daily, seed as a training reward rather than a meal, a cuttlebone in the cage, and enough flight to keep the chest muscle on. Everything on this page is downstream of that.

Respiratory disease & psittacosis

Breathing trouble in a bird is always an emergency, and this species is named first on the psittacosis list.

A bird's respiratory system has very little reserve. There is no mild version of avian breathing difficulty, and a cockatiel that is visibly working to breathe is a bird in trouble now. Learn what normal looks like while it is healthy: **40 to 50 breaths a minute at rest, with the tail perfectly still.**

SAME-DAY SIGNS

Tail bobbing with each breath, which is the bird recruiting its whole body to move air. Open-mouth breathing. A clicking, wheezing or rasping sound. A change or loss of voice, which means the problem is at the syrinx. Discharge or bubbles at the nostrils, or a stained, matted cere. Sitting fluffed with the neck stretched up. Any of these is a phone call, not a wait.

Psittacosis, and the part that concerns you

Psittacosis, or avian chlamydiosis, is caused by the bacterium *Chlamydia psittaci*. The public health compendium on this disease names **cockatiels first** among the pet birds most often behind human cases, alongside parakeets and conures, so this is not a footnote for this species.

IN THE BIRD	DETAIL
Often nothing at all	A cockatiel can carry it with no signs whatsoever, shedding it in droppings and respiratory secretions to other birds. This is why a new bird is quarantined and tested rather than trusted. Page 27
When it does show	Respiratory signs, diarrhea, weakness, and an enlarged liver. Lime-green droppings are a classic pointer. Page 26
Diagnosis	Testing at the vet. Shedding is intermittent, so one clear sample does not clear a bird
Treatment	Doxycycline. 45 days has historically been the recommendation, and shorter courses of 21 to 30 days may also be effective. Finish the course: a partial course produces a carrier

IT PASSES TO PEOPLE

In humans, illness typically begins **5 to 14 days** after exposure, with an abrupt fever, chills, headache, malaise and muscle aches, and a dry cough that can come with breathlessness or chest tightness. It responds to antibiotics and is not something to be frightened of, but it is something to mention. **If anyone in the house develops a flu-like illness with a dry cough and there is a sick bird at home, tell the doctor there is a bird.** They will not think of it, and that one sentence is what gets it treated properly.

The other causes, in rough order

- **Vitamin A deficiency**, which weakens the airway lining and lets everything else in. Page 20
- **Bacterial and fungal infection**, including aspergillosis, which is favored by damp, dirty bedding and poor ventilation
- **Inhaled irritants**: aerosols, smoke, scented candles, dusty substrate. Page 8
- **PTFE exposure**, where the usual sign is a dead bird rather than a sick one. Page 8
- **Goiter**, an iodine deficiency of all-seed birds, which presses on the airway and sounds exactly like a respiratory infection. Named in budgerigars specifically, worth asking about in any seed-fed bird with an unexplained breathing noise

WARMTH ON THE WAY IN

A bird struggling to breathe should travel warm, dark and quiet in a small covered carrier, with as little handling as possible. Stress alone kills birds in respiratory distress. Do not open the carrier to check on it every two minutes.

PBFD, polyomavirus & other viral disease

The reason a new bird is quarantined and tested, rather than introduced.

Psittacine beak and feather disease

PBFD is a circovirus affecting **over 50 species of bird**, concentrated in parrots from Africa, Australia, New Zealand and Indonesia, which puts the cockatiel squarely in the susceptible group. It is rare in New World parrots such as macaws, amazons and conures. Infection can happen at any age but is **most common in birds under three years old**.

FORM	WHO	WHAT HAPPENS
Peracute	Newly hatched chicks	Death, often before any feather sign
Acute	Young birds growing their first feathers	Rapid, severe feather abnormality during that development
Chronic	Older birds	Progressive worsening at each successive molt, which is how most owners meet it

Signs. Feathers come in stunted, club-shaped, or pinched off at the shaft, with premature molting and eventually bald areas. In cockatoos, and the cockatiel is one, **the beak becomes elongated, excessively flaky or unusually shiny, and breaks easily**, because the powder down that normally dusts and dulls the beak has failed. A glossy beak on a cockatiel is worth a mention to your vet.

Spread and diagnosis. The virus enters through the mouth, nose or cloaca and is shed heavily in droppings, crop secretions and **feather dust**, which is what makes shared air a route. Incubation is anything from **weeks to years**. Diagnosis is a blood test or an oral swab for the virus DNA, or a skin and feather biopsy.

THERE IS NO TREATMENT AND NO CURE

Most affected birds die of secondary infections within months to years. That is the entire reason page 27 exists as a page: a quarantine of 30 to 45 days with a PCR panel before a new bird joins an existing one is the only control you have, and it is cheap compared with what it prevents.

Avian polyomavirus

A second virus quarantine is designed to catch, and one that behaves very differently. It is most associated with budgerigars, where it is known as budgerigar fledgling disease, but it infects other psittacines including cockatiels. The dangerous form is in unweaned chicks, where it causes crop stasis, hemorrhage under the skin, and death within a day or two, and it is largely a breeder and pet-shop problem rather than a risk to a settled adult bird. A vaccine exists and is used in aviaries. Its practical relevance to a pet owner is the same as PBFD's: it is on the PCR panel, and it is a reason not to buy a bird from a shop with sick birds in the next cage.

What to ask for before you buy

- Whether the bird has been **tested for PBFD, polyomavirus and chlamydia**, and to see the results
- Whether any bird in the building has been ill in the last month
- Whether birds from different sources share air, dishes, or a cleaning cloth
- Whether you can return the bird if a vet check within a week finds something. A good breeder says yes without hesitating

BOOK THE WELL-BIRD EXAM FOR WEEK ONE

Not week four. A baseline exam on a bird that looks fine gives your vet a healthy reference to compare against later, catches the things you cannot see, and starts the relationship you will want at 10pm in year six. Budget it as part of the purchase, on page 30.

Foreign bodies, heavy metal, mites & injuries

The shorter conditions, including two the cockatiel is specifically known for.

Swallowed rope and fabric

Cockatiels are noted as frequent offenders for ingesting **rope fibers**, and the combination of curiosity and a beak built for exploring makes it a real risk in an under-proofed home. A swallowed length of fiber can obstruct the gut or, worse, act as a linear foreign body that saws through it. The same behavior wraps loose threads around a toe and cuts off the blood supply.

Prevention: inspect rope perches and fabric toys weekly, retire anything frayed rather than trimming it, and keep the bird off blankets and knitted things out of the cage. Signs of an obstruction are regurgitation, straining, a sudden stop in droppings, and a bird that goes quiet. Same-day vet.

Heavy metal poisoning

The other thing this species is known for swallowing. Sources and signs are on page 8; what matters here is that both **lead and zinc are treatable** with chelation if caught, and that the signs, weight loss, regurgitation, diarrhea, weakness, excessive drinking, incoordination and seizures, look like a dozen other things. A bird with unexplained neurological signs gets a metal level checked. Zinc chelates faster than lead, because zinc is not stored in bone.

Giardia, and the itch nobody expects

THE COCKATIEL DIFFERENTIAL WORTH KNOWING

Giardia is an intestinal protozoal parasite that **cockatiels are specifically noted as susceptible to**, and its effect is not what you would guess. VCA describes infected birds as having loose stools *or* being **intensely itchy, attacking themselves violently, especially under the wings**, and that itch can drive a feather-destructive habit that then looks entirely behavioral. Read the *or*: plenty show only the itch, with a normal tray throughout, so a clear tray rules nothing out. A cockatiel plucking under the wings gets a fecal test before anyone rearranges the cage. Page 24.

The rest, briefly

CONDITION	WHAT TO KNOW
Candida	A yeast overgrowth, common after antibiotics or on a poor diet. Regurgitation, weight loss, diarrhea, reduced appetite. Treatable
Scaly face mite	Crusty, honeycombed growth at the cere, beak edges and around the eyes, sometimes on the legs. More classic in budgies but seen in cockatiels. Treated by a vet with ivermectin-class drugs, and the whole cage is treated with the bird
Broken blood feather	Bleeds freely when snapped. Firm, steady pressure with clean gauze, and styptic powder or cornstarch on the exposed broken tip, never into an open follicle . Vet at two to three minutes. Do not pull it: VCA does not recommend pulling a blood feather at home, and even in clinic it is a last resort. In a 90 g bird a few milliliters matters
Overgrown beak or nails	Nails wear on varied perches. An overgrown or misshapen <i>beak</i> is different: it is a sign of liver disease, mites or trauma, not a grooming failure. Page 20
Bumblefoot	Pressure sores under the foot, from identical perches, obesity or a dirty cage. Page 6 prevents it
Cat or dog contact	A cat's mouth carries <i>Pasteurella</i> , which at a bird's body temperature can turn septic within hours, from a wound too small to find. Any cat contact is a same-day vet visit for antibiotics, even if the bird seems fine

Feather plucking & behavioral health

Easier to prevent than to reverse, and it is a medical question before it is a behavioral one.

Feather-destructive behavior is the bird damaging or removing its own feathers, most often on the chest, legs, and under the wings, where it can reach. The head is the one place a bird cannot pluck itself, which is a useful diagnostic: **feather loss including the head is a disease, not a habit.** Everything else needs working through.

A VET VISIT COMES FIRST, EVERY TIME

Assuming plucking is behavioral before a vet has ruled out a medical cause is the commonest and costliest mistake with this species. The medical list is long and several of its entries are specifically cockatiel problems: *Giardia* and its violent under-wing itch (page 23), vitamin A deficiency (page 20), PBFD (page 22), bacterial skin infection, and pain from an internal problem. Fix a real cause and the behavior often stops. Rearrange the cage instead and you lose months.

The behavioral drivers, in rough order

DRIVER	WHAT TO CHANGE
Boredom and an empty day	Food out of the bowl and into foraging. The single highest-value change. Page 13
Insufficient company	A flock bird alone all day is chronically stressed. Page 9
Sleep debt	Count the actual hours of dark. It is very often nine. Page 7
Hormonal frustration	A hen with a cavity and long days, or a bird bonded to a mirror. Page 17
A change in routine	A new work schedule, a move, a new person or pet. Plucking that starts within weeks of a change usually names its own cause
Dry air and no bathing	Regular bathing or misting helps more than owners expect. Offer a bath daily
Attention learning	If plucking reliably brings you across the room, it now has a second function. Reward calm, ignore the act itself

Catching it early

The window matters. Established plucking becomes self-soothing and habitual, and can continue after the original cause is gone, which is why prevention is worth so much more than treatment here. Watch for time spent preening one specific area beyond normal grooming, small bald patches on the chest or under the wings appearing gradually, and any increase in agitation that coincides with a change at home. Act at the first two, not at the bald patch.

SCREAMING IS THE SAME CONVERSATION

Persistent screaming in a cockatiel is almost always a contact call from a bird that has lost its flock, and it responds to the same list: more company, more to do, more sleep, a predictable routine. What makes it worse is reacting to it, because any reliable response, including an annoyed one, teaches the bird that the call worked. Answer the quiet chirps and the whistles instead. That is the whole technique.

WHEN TO BRING IN A PROFESSIONAL

If plucking escalates after several weeks of consistent change, or if the bird has broken skin or drawn blood, do two things in parallel: an avian vet visit to rule out a medical cause, and a referral to a certified avian behaviorist if the bird is cleared. Waiting makes the behavior more entrenched, and this is one of the few cases where the specialist is genuinely better than more effort.

Molt & seasonal behavior

The normal process people mistake for illness, and the abnormal one people mistake for molt.

What a normal molt looks like

Molting is the orderly replacement of the whole plumage, usually once or twice a year, most often after the breeding season. Merck's picture is a full molt at least annually, with many birds also running a smaller partial molt about six months after the main one. Feathers are shed and regrown in a **symmetrical, staggered pattern**, matching feathers going on each wing so the bird can still fly, and new feathers push up before the old ones drop. You should never see a bald bird. What you will see is loose feathers on the cage floor and **pin feathers**: new feathers still encased in a waxy keratin sheath, which look like short spines, particularly around the head and neck.

DURING A MOLT	WHAT IS HAPPENING
Quieter, touchier, sleeps more	Growing a full set of feathers is metabolically expensive. A molting bird is genuinely tired and its head is full of sore pin feathers. Handle less, scratch gently
Eats more	The demand for protein and calcium rises sharply. This is the time for a little cooked egg, and for making sure the pellets are actually being eaten
Wants more bathing	Misting or a shallow dish softens the sheaths. Keep the daily bath going
Off food, briefly	Heavy molt is a recognized reason a cockatiel goes off its food. Watch the scale. A drop is still a drop
Head scratches become a favor	Only the flock can open the sheaths on the head. Gentle rolling of a sheath between finger and thumb is welcomed by a tame bird, but never touch a sheath that is still blue at the base

THE THREE-WAY DIFFERENTIAL OWNERS GET WRONG

Molt: symmetrical, new feathers visibly coming through, feathers found intact on the cage floor, head included, bird otherwise well.

Plucking: asymmetrical, confined to where the bird can reach, **head feathers untouched**, chewed or broken shafts left behind. Page 24.

PBFD: feathers coming in wrong rather than falling out, club-shaped, pinched or stunted, worsening at each molt, often with a shiny or flaking beak. Page 22.

If you cannot tell, photograph the bird and the floor and take both to the vet.

The hormonal season

Cockatiels are triggered into breeding condition by lengthening days and abundant food, and in the northern hemisphere that usually means spring, though housed birds under artificial light lose the seasonality and can go hormonal at any time, including autumn. What you will see: more regurgitating onto a toy, mirror or hand, more territorial defense of the cage, a hen shredding paper and hunting for cavities, a cock whistling incessantly and displaying with wings held out and heart-shaped, and a general increase in biting.

None of it is bad behavior and none of it responds to discipline. It responds to the levers on page 17: shorten the day, remove the cavities, stop the body petting, and move the food into foraging.

SUPPORT THE MOLT, DO NOT MEDICATE IT

A molting bird needs food, sleep, water to bathe in, and to be left alone a bit. It does not need a molt supplement, and a bird eating 75 to 80% pellets is already getting what those products sell. If a molt drags on for months, goes bald in patches, or the bird stays unwell after it, that is a vet visit rather than a longer molt.

Reading droppings & hydration

The cheapest daily health check you own, and the reason the tray is lined with plain paper.

A bird dropping has **three components**, and telling them apart is the whole skill. The **feces** is the solid, formed, coiled part. The **urates** are the chalky white part, uric acid crystals that let a bird excrete nitrogen with almost no water. The **urine** is the clear liquid halo around the outside. Any of the three can change independently, and which one changed is what tells you where the problem is.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS
Green feces , formed, in a seed-fed bird	Normal. Diet colors the fecal part: seed-eating birds pass green feces
Brown feces , formed, in a pellet-fed bird	Normal. Expect the color to change when you convert the diet, and do not panic at it
Red, pink or purple	Almost always berries or beetroot, and it lasts a day. If the bird has eaten nothing colored, it is blood, and it is a same-day call
Lime green or yellow-green	A liver pointer, and a classic sign of psittacosis. Page 21. Vet
Black or tarry	Digested blood from higher in the gut. Vet, today
Yellow or green urates	The white part should be white. Colored urates point at the liver. Vet
Watery, but the feces still formed	Polyuria , excess urine, not diarrhea. Usually a watery meal, sometimes stress. Persisting with no fruit in the last day raises kidney disease, and VCA notes polyuria is often the first sign of kidney damage from zinc. Page 8
Unformed feces, no solid part	True diarrhea , which is much less common than owners think and much more serious. Vet
Undigested seed in the dropping	Food passing through unabsorbed. Always abnormal, and Merck lists whole seed in the droppings as a sign of avian gastric yeast, where a bird keeps eating and still loses weight. Vet, and weigh the bird
Far fewer droppings than yesterday	The bird is not eating, or is obstructed. Both matter. Page 19

WHOLE SEED IN THE DROPPINGS HAS A NAME

Merck lists it as a sign of **avian gastric yeast**, *Macrorhabdus ornithogaster*, and names cockatiels among the species it most affects; one case series found it more often in cockatiels than budgerigars. The bird eats normally, or ravenously, and loses weight anyway: a falling number on the scale (page 16) before it is anything you can see. Shedding is intermittent, so one clear sample rules nothing out.

THE 24-HOUR RULE

Get familiar with your own bird's normal droppings, because once you know them, anything else is abnormal by definition. A single odd dropping is not an emergency; you changed the food, or it ate a blueberry.

Droppings that stay abnormal for more than about 24 hours are a vet visit. Photograph the paper before you throw it away, and take the photo with you.

Hydration

A dehydrated bird has dry, tacky mouth tissue, dull sunken eyes, skin over the keel that stays tented when gently lifted, and urates that go thick and yellow. Cockatiels drink relatively little and get a real share of their water from fresh food, which is one more reason page 11 matters. Change water daily, and again after a bath: a cockatiel will bathe in its drinking bowl and then be reluctant to drink from it.

LINE THE TRAY SO YOU CAN READ IT

Plain paper, changed daily, no grate in the way if you can manage it. Corncob, sand and wood chip all hide droppings, absorb them, and grow mold underneath, which turns the most informative surface in the cage into the least. Page 6.

Quarantine & adding a second bird

The one page that protects a bird you already own. Skipping it is how a healthy flock ends.

A new bird can carry PBFD, polyomavirus or chlamydia with no visible sign at all, shedding all three in droppings, crop secretions and feather dust. Quarantine is not about whether the new bird looks well. It looks well precisely because that is how these diseases work.

30 TO 45 DAYS, AND TEST

Every new bird, including one back from a show, sale or event, gets **at least 30 days** in a separate room, and the plan is **30 to 45**, with testing before it meets another bird. The more established birds you already keep, the nearer the long end to run. For an aviary or an established group, Merck's figure is **90 days** with testing, because an infected adult can shed polyomavirus intermittently for up to 90 days before clearing it. There is no version of this that takes a weekend.

How to actually run it

RULE	WHY
A separate room , ideally not on the same air handling	Feather dust carries PBFD, and it travels further than droppings do. A different floor is better than a different corner
Separate dishes, tools, and cleaning cloths	Cross-contamination is usually a bucket or a sponge, not the birds
Established birds first, new bird last	Do the whole daily routine for the resident bird before you go near the new one, every day, without exceptions
Wash hands and change your shirt	Feather dust sits on clothing. This is the step people skip
A vet exam and a PCR panel in week one	PBFD, polyomavirus and chlamydia. This is what quarantine is <i>for</i> ; quarantine without testing is just waiting
Weigh the new bird daily	You are looking for the thing it is hiding. Page 16

Then the introduction

1. **Cages side by side, a few feet apart**, for several days. Let them see and call to each other with no contact
2. **Move the cages closer** over a week, watching for interest rather than lunging at the bars
3. **Neutral ground first**. The first physical meeting happens on a play stand or a table, never inside either cage, and never inside the resident bird's cage. That is the resident's territory and it will be defended
4. **Short supervised sessions**, extended as they get boring. Beak sparring, squabbling over perches and a lot of noise are normal. Pulled feathers or any blood mean separate cages for good
5. **A shared cage last**, and only if it is genuinely big enough for two, with two of every resource so nothing is worth guarding. Full acceptance takes weeks to months

THEY MAY SIMPLY NOT LIKE EACH OTHER

Cockatiels are social but they are not indiscriminate, and a pairing can fail. Have a plan for two cages permanently before you buy the second bird, not after. Two birds who live beside each other and call back and forth are still much better company than one bird alone.

QUARANTINE EVEN IF IT IS YOUR ONLY BIRD

A 30-day settling period in a quiet room, with a vet exam at the start of it, is good for a single new bird too. It catches problems while your expectations are still forming, it gives the bird the low-stimulus start page 14 asks for, and it means you find out about a health problem before you have fallen in love with the bird.

Setup checklist & targets

Print this one. Work down it before the bird arrives, or use it to audit a setup you already have.

The cage

- ☐ Footprint at least 20×20 in (51×51 cm), target 24×24×30 in (61×61×76 cm) or wider
- ☐ Bar spacing measured at 1/2 in (13 mm)
- ☐ Wider than it is tall, with a clear flight line
- ☐ Not galvanized. Powder-coated or stainless
- ☐ Door catch a cockatiel cannot work open
- ☐ Pull-out tray, lined with plain paper
- ☐ Perches in three diameters, 1/2 to 3/4 in (13 to 19 mm)
- ☐ At least one natural branch, one rope, one swing
- ☐ No sandpaper perch covers
- ☐ Two food dishes and one water dish, none under a perch
- ☐ Cuttlebone and mineral block, permanently
- ☐ No happy hut, nest box, tent or mirror

The room

- ☐ Against a wall, at or near eye level, in a used room
- ☐ Not the kitchen, and not on the same air as it
- ☐ Out of all-day sun and off any draft
- ☐ Dim night light fitted and working
- ☐ Nonstick cookware replaced or the bird permanently distant
- ☐ Aerosols, candles and plug-ins out of the bird's rooms
- ☐ 10 to 12 hours of real darkness achievable here
- ☐ Houseplants checked, blinds cords secured

Food, kit and paperwork

- ☐ Formulated cockatiel pellets bought
- ☐ A week of dark green and dark orange vegetables
- ☐ Millet, for training only
- ☐ No grit anywhere in the house
- ☐ Shallow bathing dish
- ☐ Digital scale reading in 1 g steps, with a perch fitted
- ☐ Travel carrier, assembled and tried
- ☐ First-aid box packed. Page 29
- ☐ Avian vet found, and the after-hours number written down
- ☐ Well-bird exam booked for week one

The numbers, all in one place

Cage footprint	20×20 in floor, 24×24×30 in target
Bar spacing	1/2 in (13 mm)
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C)
Darkness	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted, with a dim night light
Diet	75 to 80% pellets, 20 to 25% fresh, seed as a treat
Weight	80 to 125 g, average 90. Track your bird's own baseline
Out-of-cage time	An hour or more a day, every day, for a single bird

Emergency & quick targets card

Fill this in today. Cut it out and put it on the fridge, not in a drawer.

AVIAN VET

Name _____

Phone _____

Hours _____

AFTER HOURS / EMERGENCY

Name _____

Phone _____

Drive time _____

THIS BIRD

Name _____

Hatch / purchase date _____

Sex, and how confirmed _____

Baseline weight (g) _____

POISON CONTROL / BACKUP

Poison line _____

Trusted sitter _____

Phone _____

GO NOW, DO NOT WAIT UNTIL MORNING

Laboured breathing, tail bobbing, open beak, clicking. Bleeding from anywhere. Sitting on the cage floor. A hen straining or with a swollen abdomen. Any cat or dog contact, however small. A fall, a burn, or a suspected PTFE exposure. Sudden collapse, seizures, or one-sided weakness. Discharge from eyes, nose or mouth.

Targets, at a glance

Cage floor / target	20×20 in (51×51 cm) / 24×24×30 in (61×61×76 cm)
Bar spacing	1/2 in (13 mm)
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C)
Warm carrier, sick bird	About 80°F (27°C). Too hot looks like sleek feathers, wings out, open beak
Darkness, normal	10 to 12 hours, night light on
Light, to stop laying	8 hours a day, under vet advice
Diet split	75 to 80% pellets / 20 to 25% fresh / seed as a treat
Weight, act on	A 10% fall, three falling weighings, or 1 to 2% a week in a diet change
Breathing at rest	40 to 50 a minute, tail still
Abnormal droppings	Vet if unchanged after about 24 hours
Quarantine a new bird	30 to 45 days, up to 90 for a flock, plus testing

Dates to write down

Pellet bag opened _____

Cuttlebone replaced _____

Last wellness exam _____

Next exam due _____

THE FIRST-AID KIT, IN A LABELED BOX

Cornstarch or styptic powder, sterile gauze, blunt-tipped scissors, a small towel, a travel carrier, a controllable heat source, saline, a flashlight for backlighting a dark nail, and the vet's number taped to the lid. Keep it where anyone can find it in the dark.

Budget & shopping list

Itemized, and the lines add up to the totals. US dollars, 2026.

Getting set up

ITEM	LOW	REALISTIC
Cage, 24×24×30 in or wider	\$100	\$260
Perches, three diameters, natural and rope	\$20	\$40
Stainless dishes, three	\$10	\$25
Cuttlebone and mineral block	\$5	\$12
Toys, including two foraging toys	\$25	\$55
Dim night light	\$8	\$15
Digital scale, 1 g steps	\$12	\$25
Travel carrier	\$25	\$50
First bag of pellets	\$12	\$25
Cage cover or a second sleep cage	\$15	\$70
Equipment subtotal	\$232	\$577
The bird, by mutation	\$75	\$250
Well-bird exam, week one	\$85	\$200
Total to be properly set up	\$392	\$1,027

Every year after that

ITEM	LOW	REALISTIC
Pellets	\$65	\$105
Fresh vegetables and fruit	\$75	\$125
Toys, rotated and replaced	\$35	\$65
Paper liner, cleaning supplies	\$15	\$30
Cuttlebone, mineral block, perch replacement	\$10	\$25
Food, toys and upkeep	\$200	\$350
Avian wellness exam, at least one a year	\$85	\$200
Annual total, one bird	\$285	\$550
Which is, per month	\$24	\$46
A bonded pair, per year: roughly 1.8 times one bird, not double	\$515	\$990

THE LINE NOBODY BUDGETS FOR

A reproductive emergency, the likeliest one in this species, runs **\$300 to \$800 or more**, and diagnostics sit on top of the exam fee. Bird insurance barely exists, so almost every owner self-insures, and that only works if the money is somewhere. Put \$20 a month aside from the day the bird arrives.

WHERE TO SAVE, AND WHERE NOT TO

Not the cage, because a small one gets replaced within a year. Not the bar spacing, because it is a safety limit. Not the pellets, because the whole of section 03 runs through the food bowl. **Do** save on toys, which are paper, cardboard and untreated wood, and on perches, which grow on unsprayed apple and willow for free.

First 30 days checklist

In order. The first two weeks are mostly about doing less than you want to.

Days 1 to 3: leave it alone

- ☐ Cage set up and standing *before* the bird came home, in its permanent spot
- ☐ Whatever food the bird was already on, in the dish. Change the diet later, not now
- ☐ Night light on from the first night
- ☐ Sit in the room and talk or read aloud. No hands in the cage
- ☐ Weigh daily and start the log on page 36

Week 1

- ☐ Well-bird exam booked and attended, with a PCR panel if there is another bird in the house
- ☐ Quarantine room set up if you have other birds. Page 27
- ☐ Baseline weight established across seven days
- ☐ Droppings photographed once so you know what normal looks like
- ☐ Millet offered through the bars, no hands inside yet
- ☐ Sleep routine fixed: same lights-out time every night

Week 2

- ☐ Hand resting inside the cage holding millet, still and patient
- ☐ First vegetables offered, in several formats. Expect refusal. Page 11
- ☐ Pellet conversion started, one method chosen. Page 10
- ☐ Weight watched daily: over 1 to 2% lost in a week means slow down
- ☐ Foraging toy introduced with food visible on top, not hidden inside

Week 3

- ☐ Step-up cue introduced, in 10 to 15 minute sessions. Page 14
- ☐ Daily bath started: a shallow dish or a light misting
- ☐ Room bird-proofed and the pre-flight check practiced. Page 8
- ☐ Pellet share visibly increasing, seed share falling

Week 4

- ☐ First supervised out-of-cage session, doors and windows shut, fan off
- ☐ Recall training started with millet. Page 15
- ☐ Sex confirmed if the bird is a normal gray, or a DNA test ordered. Page 16
- ☐ Toys rotated for the first time, not added to
- ☐ Emergency card on page 29 filled in and on the fridge
- ☐ Next wellness exam pencilled into the planner on page 37

WHAT NORMAL SETTling LOOKS LIKE

A new cockatiel eats less than usual for a few days, sits still and watchful, and may be silent for a week before it whistles at all. That is a bird assessing a new environment, not a sick bird, and the difference is the scale. A quiet, watchful bird holding its weight is settling. A quiet bird losing weight is ill. Page 19.

Symptom quick reference

What you can see, what it usually means, and how fast to move.

WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY CAUSES	ACT
Tail bobbing, open beak, clicking	Respiratory disease, psittacosis, aspergillosis, vitamin A deficiency, goiter, PTFE exposure	Today. Page 21
Sitting on the cage floor	Advanced illness of almost any kind, egg binding, injury, poisoning	Today. Page 19
Straining, swollen abdomen, wide stance, leg weakness	Egg binding	Today. Page 18
Bleeding	Broken blood feather, night fright injury, cat or dog contact, toe caught in fabric	Firm, steady pressure; powder on a broken tip, never into the follicle. Vet at 2 to 3 minutes. Page 23
Weight down about 10% from baseline	Failing pellet conversion, illness, parasites, megabacteria, tumor	Today. Page 16
Sneezing, wet or stained cere, swollen eye	Vitamin A deficiency, upper airway infection, an irritant in the room	24 hours. Pages 20, 8
Lime-green droppings	Liver disease, psittacosis	24 hours. Page 26
Watery droppings, feces still formed	Polyuria: watery food, stress, or kidney disease	Vet if it persists past 24 hours
Unformed droppings, no solid part	True diarrhea. <i>Giardia</i> , bacterial infection, psittacosis	24 hours. Page 26
Violent itching, attacking under the wings	<i>Giardia</i> . This is the cockatiel one	Fecal test. Page 23
Feathers chewed or missing, head untouched	Plucking: medical first, then boredom, sleep debt, hormones	Vet, then page 24
Feathers stunted, clubbed or pinched, shiny beak	PBFD	PCR test. Page 22
Symmetrical feather loss, pin feathers, still well	A normal molt	Support it. Page 25
Regurgitating onto a toy, mirror or your hand	Courtship behavior, not illness. Vomiting sticks to the face and chest instead	Page 17
Thrashing panic in the dark	A night fright	Light on, check for blood. Page 7
Lame, or not bearing weight on one leg	Injury, egg pressing on nerves, heavy metal, tumor	24 hours. Pages 23, 18
Excessive drinking and urination	Vitamin A deficiency, kidney disease, lead or zinc, diabetes	24 hours. Page 20
Screaming, escalating through the day	An unmet contact call: company, sleep, occupation	Page 24
Crusty honeycombed cere or beak edges	Scaly face mite	Vet. Page 23

A RULE FOR THE AMBIGUOUS CASES

In a bird this size, "wait and see" costs more than a consultation does. If two things on this page are true at once, or if anything at all is true alongside a falling weight, treat it as the urgent version rather than the mild one.

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

What good care actually looks like as a set of habits.

Every day

- ☐ Uncover and greet at roughly the same time
- ☐ Fresh water, dish washed not topped up
- ☐ Pellet bowl refreshed in the morning
- ☐ Fresh vegetables in, and out again after two hours
- ☐ Part of the ration into a foraging toy
- ☐ Paper liner changed, droppings read as you do it
- ☐ Weighed before breakfast and logged. Page 36
- ☐ An hour or more out of the cage, with you
- ☐ Bath offered in the morning
- ☐ Two short training sessions, five minutes each
- ☐ Look the bird over: posture, breathing, feet, cere, vent
- ☐ Treat about half an hour before lights out
- ☐ Lights out at the same time, night light on
- ☐ Pre-flight check before any free flight. Page 8

Every week

- ☐ Weight trend compared with last week. Page 36
- ☐ Rotate toys rather than adding more
- ☐ Scrub perches and dishes properly
- ☐ Inspect rope and fabric for fraying, retire anything loose
- ☐ A spritz or two for a bird that will not bathe
- ☐ Check nails and beak during a head scratch

Every month

- ☐ Cage deep clean, tray and grate included
- ☐ Cuttlebone and mineral block checked and replaced
- ☐ Perches replaced or re-cut as they wear
- ☐ Weight trend reviewed across the month, not just today

Seasonally, and once a year

WHEN	WHAT
Lengthening days, usually spring	Hormonal season. Watch for regurgitating, cavity hunting, territorial biting. Tighten the photoperiod, remove cavities, stop body petting. Page 17
After breeding season	Molt. Expect a quieter, hungrier, touchier bird for several weeks. More protein, more bathing, less handling. Page 25
Winter	Drier air and more heating. Bathe more often, keep the cage off drafts and away from radiators, and remember an oven's self-clean cycle is a PTFE source
At least once a year	Wellness exam with an avian vet, even when nothing is wrong, and many vets advise two. This is the appointment that catches what the bird is hiding

Enrichment log

DATE	WHAT WAS OFFERED	ENGAGED?	NOTES

Power outages, travel & transport

For a bird, the danger in an outage is not the cold. It is what people light to fix the cold.

THE RULE THAT INVERTS FROM EVERY OTHER PET

A reptile in a power cut is a temperature problem. **A cockatiel in a power cut is a fumes problem.** Candles, kerosene and propane heaters, a gas stove left on for warmth, and a wood stove that smokes are all far more dangerous to a 90 g bird than a cold night is. A generator runs outside and **at least 20 feet from any door, window or vent**, the CDC's figure, and the CPSC rules out running one in or *near* an enclosed space, so an open garage door does not qualify. Keep a working carbon monoxide detector in the house. If the power goes out, the first thing you decide is what you are *not* going to light in the bird's air.

If the power goes out

- **Keep feeding.** A cockatiel has almost no energy reserve and eats through the day. Food and water stay available whatever else is happening
- **Move the cage to the warmest interior room**, away from windows and exterior doors, and cover three sides with blankets to hold warmth while leaving airflow at the front
- **Body heat beats fire.** A carrier under a blanket in an occupied room, or a covered hot water bottle the bird cannot touch directly, is safer than any flame
- **Ventilate anything you do burn.** If a heater has to run, it runs in a different room with the door closed and a window cracked, and the bird is not in that room
- **Keep the night light plan.** A battery night light in the emergency box means an outage does not also become a night fright. Page 7

The go bag

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Travel carrier with a low fixed perch | ☐ Battery night light and a flashlight |
| ☐ Three days of pellets in a sealed bag | ☐ Towel, paper liner, first-aid box |
| ☐ Bottled water and a clip-on dish | ☐ A copy of pages 29 and 35 |
| ☐ Millet, for a bird refusing to eat | ☐ Photo of the bird, on your phone and printed |

In the car

RULE	WHY
A carrier, not the cage	A cage is a box of perches and toys to be thrown around in. A small carrier with one low perch is safer, and the reduced space calms most birds rather than distressing them
Cover it	Less visual input, much less stress. Leave one side open for airflow
Belt it in, on the back seat	Never loose on a seat, never a lap, never the front seat with an airbag
No water dish on the road	A full dish soaks the bird and a soaked bird chills fast. A slice of fruit or a leafy green covers a short drive
Never leave the bird in a parked car	Not for five minutes. A closed car in the sun kills a bird faster than it kills a dog, and cold does it almost as quickly
No air freshener, no smoking, no vaping	A car is a very small volume of air. Page 8

PRACTICE BEFORE YOU NEED TO

Leave the carrier open in the room for a week, put millet in it, and let the bird go in and out on its own. A bird that has already chosen to sit in the carrier is a bird you can move in ninety seconds during an evacuation, and one that has never seen it is a chase in a smoke-filled house.

Pet-sitter sheet

Fill it in, print it, and leave it taped near the cage. Assume the sitter has never kept a bird.

THE BIRD

Name _____

Sex _____

Normal weight (g) _____

REACH ME

Phone _____

Backup contact _____

Vet + after hours _____

Every day, please

- ☐ Fresh water in a washed dish. The bird will bathe in it and it will need changing again
- ☐ Refill the pellet bowl in the morning. Pellets are the main food, not a supplement
- ☐ Fresh vegetables in the morning, and out again after about two hours
- ☐ Change the paper in the tray, and glance at the droppings while you do it
- ☐ Talk to the bird. Ten minutes near the cage is worth more than you would think
- ☐ Lights out at the usual time, and **leave the night light on**

PLEASE NEVER, IN THIS HOUSE

Do not use nonstick cookware. An overheated nonstick pan releases a gas that kills birds, often with no other sign. Use the stainless or cast iron pans.

No aerosols, air fresheners, scented candles or plug-ins anywhere in the house while the bird is here.

Do not let the bird out of the cage unless we have specifically arranged it and shown you how.

Do not turn the night light off. This species panics in total darkness and injures itself on the bars.

No avocado, chocolate, caffeine, alcohol, onion or garlic, ever, in any amount.

Call me if you see

- ☐ The bird sitting on the floor of the cage
- ☐ Breathing with an open beak, or the tail pumping
- ☐ Blood anywhere
- ☐ Fluffed up and not moving much, for hours
- ☐ No droppings on the paper since yesterday
- ☐ An egg. Please leave it exactly where it is and call

Where things are

Pellets _____

Vegetables and treats _____

Paper liner and cleaning kit _____

Carrier and first-aid box _____

Lights out at _____

Anything else _____

Owner log

Weigh daily, at the same time of day, before the first feed, and never skip it through a diet conversion, a molt, or a laying period. Write the number even when it is boring, because the boring numbers are what make one interesting number readable. Act on a drop of more than about 10% from the bird's own baseline, any steady decline across three weighings, or more than 1 to 2% lost in a week during a diet change. Take this page to the vet.

Equipment & vet log

What was replaced, what was treated, and what is due next.

Equipment & consumables

ITEM	REPLACED	NEXT DUE	NOTES
Perches			
Cuttlebone / mineral block			
Pellet bag opened			
Night light bulb			

Veterinary

DATE	REASON	WEIGHT (G)	FINDINGS, TREATMENT, FOLLOW-UP

Twelve-month planner

MONTH	WEIGHED	WELLNESS EXAM	CAGE DEEP CLEAN	NOTES
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	

REFERENCE

Glossary

Terms used in this book, in the sense they are used here.

Blood feather	A growing feather with a live blood supply in the shaft. Dark and full at the base, and it bleeds freely if broken or cut. Page 23
Cere	The fleshy area above the beak carrying the nostrils. In a cockatiel it is small and feathered, unlike a budgie's, so it is not a sexing feature here
Chlamydiosis	Infection with <i>Chlamydia psittaci</i> . Called psittacosis in people. Page 21
Chronic egg laying	Repeated clutches out of season, driven by the environment rather than by a mate. Page 17
Contact call	A loud call used to locate flock members out of sight. Most cockatiel screaming is this. Page 24
Crop	A storage pouch at the base of the neck where food sits before digestion. Visibly full after a meal
Dimorphic	Having visibly different males and females. Cockatiels are, in the normal gray, after the first molt. Page 16
Egg binding	A hen unable to pass an egg. A same-day emergency. Page 18
Foraging	Working for food rather than eating it from a bowl. The single highest-value enrichment change. Page 13
Hepatic lipidosis	Fatty liver disease. Fat deposited in the liver, usually from a seed diet. Page 20
Hypovitaminosis A	Vitamin A deficiency. The commonest nutritional disease in pet birds. Page 20
Keel	The ridge of breastbone down the front of the bird, used to judge body condition by feel. Page 16
Molt	Orderly, symmetrical replacement of the plumage. Page 25
Night fright	A panicked thrashing episode in the dark, which cockatiels are unusually prone to. Page 7
PBFD	Psittacine beak and feather disease. An incurable circovirus. Page 22
Photoperiod	The length of the light part of the day. The main lever on hormonal behavior. Page 7
Pin feather	A new feather still in its waxy keratin sheath. Normal during a molt, sore to touch. Page 25
Polyuria	Excess urine, with the fecal part still formed. Not the same as diarrhea. Page 26
Powder down	Specialized feathers that break down into a fine dust used in grooming. Merck names cockatiels alongside cockatoos as heavy producers, which is why they film a room. Page 7
PTFE	Polytetrafluoroethylene, the nonstick coating whose fumes kill birds when overheated. Page 8
Regurgitation	Deliberate bringing up of food as courtship, aimed at a mate, a toy or a hand. Not vomiting. Page 25
Urates	The chalky white part of a dropping, uric acid rather than urine. Page 26
Zoonotic	Passing from animals to people. Psittacosis is. Page 21

REFERENCE

Sources & further reading

Where the numbers in this book came from.

Veterinary and public health sources

SOURCE	WHAT IT SUPPLIED
LafeberVet, <i>Basic Information Sheet for the Cockatiel</i>	Weight range and average, adult length, life span, sexual maturity, incubation and clutch size, weaning age, body temperature, heart and respiratory rates, minimum cage dimensions, bar spacing, household temperature range, and the sexual dimorphism of the normal gray
VCA Animal Hospitals, <i>Cockatiels: Feeding</i>	The 75 to 80% pellet and 20 to 25% fresh split, the five conversion methods, the honey stick and millet notes, the grit warning, and the supplement guidance
VCA, <i>Common Conditions of Pet Birds</i>	Psittacosis in cockatiels including asymptomatic carriage, <i>Giardia</i> and the violent under-wing itch, candida, and that reproductive problems are more common in cockatiels than in budgies
VCA, <i>Egg Binding in Birds</i>	Affected species, the clinical signs, the calcium and obesity risk factors, that small birds can die within a few hours, the treatment sequence, and the 8-hour photoperiod intervention
VCA, <i>Psittacine Beak and Feather Disease in Pet Birds</i>	The circovirus, over 50 affected species, the peracute, acute and chronic forms, the beak and powder-down signs in cockatoos, transmission and feather dust, incubation, PCR diagnosis, and prognosis
VCA, <i>Birds: Abnormal Droppings</i>	The three components, diet-related fecal color, polyuria against true diarrhea, lime-green droppings and liver disease, and the 24-hour rule
MSD / Merck Veterinary Manual, <i>Toxicoses of Pet Birds</i>	PTFE at 280°C (536°F) with acute death as the usual sign and the full source list, lead and zinc household sources and signs, aerosols and tobacco
MSD / Merck, <i>Nutritional Diseases of Pet Birds</i>	Hypovitaminosis A on seed and half-seed diets and its signs, calcium deficiency and its signs, obesity at roughly 20% over ideal weight, and goiter as an iodine deficiency of seed-fed birds
NASPHV and CDC, <i>Compendium of Measures to Control Chlamydia psittaci Infection Among Humans and Pet Birds</i>	Cockatiels named first among implicated pet species, the 30-day quarantine with testing, the 45-day doxycycline course and the shorter 21 to 30 day option, and the human incubation period and illness picture
Lafeber (Lamb, Orosz); LafeberVet, <i>Avian Emergency and Critical Care</i> ; VCA, <i>Wing Clipping, Blood or Pin Feathers, Nursing Care, Beak and Nail Care</i>	Conversion limits and the 10% weight threshold; daily weighing; the 75 to 80°F sick-bird and 80 to 90°F supplemental heat ranges and overheating signs; blood-feather first aid and why a feather is not pulled at home; the 48-hour egg marker; the quick and the cut-quick sequence on page 6
Merck, <i>Management, Viral, Mycotic and Digestive Diseases of Pet Birds</i> ; case series on <i>Macrorhabdus</i> ; NHLBI, <i>Hypersensitivity Pneumonitis</i>	Four to seven outermost primaries with secondaries left alone, and no fixed molt interval; the 90-day aviary quarantine; avian gastric yeast on page 26; bird fancier's lung on page 7, with pet birds in the home as a risk factor and the 50 to 70 age band
UC Davis Clinical Animal Behavior Service; US CDC and CPSC	The 10 to 12 hour sleep figure and that covering a cage may not give optimal rest; the 20-foot generator distance and carbon monoxide guidance
Lafeber, <i>Night Fright in Birds</i>	The mechanism, the night light recommendation, partial rather than full covering, identifying external triggers, and the response when one happens
<i>Applied Animal Behaviour Science</i> , cockatiel enrichment studies (2020 and 2025)	That environmental enrichment improves behavior and welfare in captive cockatiels, with reduced feather-damaging behavior singled out, and the under-one-hour foraging time of bowl-fed parrots
VCA, <i>Bathing Birds and New Bird Visit</i> ; Lafeber, <i>Add Another Cockatiel?</i> ; University of Florida Small Animal Hospital	The daily morning bath; the first exam within one to two weeks and checkups at least yearly; two cocks as the pairing with no eggs; the 1 to 2% weekly weight limit in a diet change

Beastly Facts guides drawn on: the six cockatiel guides, the budgie and cockatoo comparisons, and sixteen cross-species bird guides, from household hazards and quarantine to first aid and feather dust. Where they disagreed with a veterinary source, the veterinary source is what is printed here.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Five figures where credible references do not match, and what this book prints instead.

FIGURE	THE DISAGREEMENT, AND THE CHOICE
Bar spacing	LafeberVet gives 0.5 to 0.75 in; pet care guidance gives half an inch or smaller. This book prints 1/2 in (13 mm) , the stricter figure, because the risk it guards against is head entrapment and the cost of being wrong is fatal
Cage size	Sources range from 20×20×30 in to 30×24×36 in. Neither end was picked: page 5 prints 20×20 in as the floor and 24×24×30 in as the target, and says why
Captive lifespan	LafeberVet gives 12 to 15 years with up to 25 reported. Other references give 15 to 20 and 15 to 25, and VCA gives 10 to 14 with a documented maximum of 24 , a fourth figure and the lowest of them. This book prints 12 to 15 typically, up to 25 , which is the range the species-specific veterinary sheet supports
Diet split	Some care references give 60 to 70% pellets. VCA's cockatiel feeding page gives 75 to 80% , and that is what is printed here
Cost	Published setup figures of \$320 to \$860 omit a gram scale, a carrier, a sleep cage and a real first veterinary visit. Page 30 itemizes all of them and lands at \$392 to \$1,027, with the lines summing to the totals. The yearly \$200 to \$350 is upkeep alone; the exam takes it to \$285 to \$550

Version history

VERSION	DATE	TEMPLATE	WHAT CHANGED
1.2	Oct 2026	t3	Cross-checked against the site as of October 2026. Bathing moved to a daily bath; two cocks, not two hens, named as the pairing with no eggs; quarantine set at 30 to 45 days, up to 90 for an established flock; yearly upkeep matched to \$200 to \$350 before the exam; out-of-cage time to an hour or more a day; daily weighing, with a 1 to 2% weekly limit during a diet change; sick-bird warmth to 80°F; symptom timings aligned to the 24-hour rule.
1.1	Sep 2026	t3	Corrections pass, cross-checked page by page against the site's cross-species bird articles. Blood-feather first aid corrected to firm pressure with no pulling at home; the six-to-twelve-month wing regrowth interval dropped, since Merck gives no fixed interval; the egg-binding warming figure moved from 85 to 90°F to 80 to 85°F with both sources named; the 45 to 60 day multi-bird quarantine replaced with Merck's 90 days. Added: nail-trim technique on page 6 with no interval printed, an avian gastric yeast block on page 26, a bird fancier's lung note on page 7, the 48-hour egg marker, Merck's four to seven outermost primaries, the Giardia itch-without-loose-stool point, and the droppings, molt, avocado, lead, zinc, generator and carbon monoxide figures.
1.0	Sep 2026	t3	First edition

Beastly Facts publishes fact-checked care references for keepers who would rather read one accurate thing than ten contradictory ones. This is a husbandry reference, not veterinary advice.

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